This is no political emigration but filthy trafficking in human lives conducted by despicable means in which the West Germans and US agents, most of which are working from West Berlin, invest large sums of money. Since large pensions have been given to all Nazis in West Germany, many politically incriminated persons also go to the West.

3

Meanwhile, to help sketch out a physical border, Honecker handpicked an eight-man task force. By summer, they were installed at an operations centre on the second floor of the Police Presidium on Keibelstraße near Alexanderplatz. Working from a suite of four offices with an adjoining conference room, plastered with maps and diagrammed routes, the team set about planning the dissection of Berlin. Honecker was meticulous in examining every detail personally and often ventured out to get the lay of the land. It was a massive organisational effort involving the command staff of four ministries: Defence, State Security, Interior and Transport. Those privy to the secret plans included Paul Verner, chief of the SED in Berlin, Erich Mielke, Willi Stoph and Karl Maron. Werner Hubner, a fanatically loyal army lieutenant colonel, advised on military issues, while Gerhard Exner, a police colonel, played a key role in logistical problems. Anyone holding a topographical map of Berlin could see the Wall would cross rivers, shallow lakes, streams, a canal, housing estates, bridges, woodland, railway stations and several cemeteries. They planned to quickly seal off the border with razor-sharp concertina wire which was to be gradually replaced by a brick wall. Concrete for stabilising the larger barriers would be carried in barrows, while wooden supports for the countless small barbwire fences was to be pounded into the ground by sledgehammers. Moreover, Honecker’s plans were all the more impressive given they included the separation of the U-Bahn and S-Bahn lines to West Berlin. In some places along the Spree River, underwater barriers to prevent swimmers fleeing were planned. Given the difficulties, the pace of progress was remarkable.